Should AI Be Your Study Buddy?

Podcast

Summary

In this January 2026 episode of *Approximately Correct*, Jill Kowalchuk, Amii's Manager of AI Literacy, returns to the podcast for a timely and engaging conversation about how AI in education has continued to evolve since her last appearance in 2024. Jill reflects on the astonishing pace of change, noting how generative AI tools like ChatGPT, Gemini and CoPilot have moved rapidly from being experimental curiosities to everyday classroom realities. With this shift has come both growing enthusiasm and important concerns, particularly around ethics, equity, academic integrity, and how AI may influence the way students learn and think. Rather than framing AI as something to fear or ban, Jill emphasizes the need for thoughtful engagement that keeps human learning at the center.

Drawing on her work developing and piloting AI learning kits, as part of Amii's *AI in K-12 Program*, Jill shares key lessons she has learned from collaborating closely with educators. She explains why teachers were the primary focus of this work, highlighting their essential role as decision-makers and pedagogical experts who understand their students, classrooms, and local contexts better than anyone else. Over the past year, Jill has seen strong curiosity and willingness among teachers to explore AI, paired with understandable uncertainty about how to use these tools responsibly and in ways that support students' outcomes. She stresses that meaningful progress happens when teachers are given time, support, and community, rather than one-size-fits-all solutions. This approach has helped shift conversations in schools from early panic and avoidance toward more confident, nuanced, and values-driven use of AI.

The episode also explores Jill's perspective on the evolving language around AI literacy and AI fluency, and how these terms are often used differently even though they are deeply connected. Rather than seeing fluency as something that comes after literacy, Jill argues that the ability to thoughtfully, ethically, and creatively *use* AI is an essential part of what it truly means to be AI literate in the first place. Jill discusses how students and educators can balance AI use with the development of foundational skills like critical thinking, writing, and reflection, especially in light of recent research on cognitive offloading. She shares insights from the Upper Bound conference, where strong interest and collaboration across education, policy, and technology made it clear that AI literacy is becoming a shared priority. Jill closes the conversation with practical and encouraging advice for teachers, students, and parents alike, reminding listeners to stay curious, ask questions, and approach AI as a tool that should support human creativity, judgment, and agency rather than replace it.

Key Terms

Term	Definition
AI Literacy	AI literacy is the ability to understand, question, and actively work with AI systems in informed and ethical ways. It includes knowing how AI functions, recognizing its limitations and risks, and being able to apply AI thoughtfully in real contexts. From this perspective, literacy is not just awareness or knowledge about AI, but also the capability to meaningfully use it without losing human agency.
AI Fluency	AI fluency refers to the practical, hands-on dimension of AI literacy. It is the ability to engage with AI tools creatively, critically, and responsibly in real-world situations. Rather than being a separate or "next" stage, fluency is an essential component of AI literacy itself, reflecting whether someone can actually translate understanding into informed action.
Teacher Agency	Teacher agency is the capacity for educators to make confident, context-aware decisions about how AI is used in their classrooms. It involves both AI literacy and AI fluency, ensuring teachers are not just informed about AI tools, but able to adapt, question, and shape their use in ways that support pedagogy, equity, and student learning.
Cognitive Offloading	Cognitive offloading is the practice of shifting thinking tasks such as writing, remembering, or problem-solving to tools like AI. While this can be helpful when used intentionally, overreliance can reduce deep engagement and learning if students use AI as a replacement rather than a support for their own thinking.
Metacognitive Scaffolding	Metacognitive scaffolding involves teaching students to reflect on how and when they use AI tools. It helps learners recognize when to rely on their own skills first and when AI can be used to extend, refine, or challenge their work, supporting healthy skill development alongside effective AI use.

3 Key Takeaways

1. AI literacy requires practice, not just awareness. Understanding how AI works is not enough. True AI literacy includes the ability to use AI thoughtfully, ethically, and creatively in real situations. What is often called "AI fluency" is not a separate or later step, but a core part of being genuinely AI literate.
2. Teachers are central to meaningful and responsible AI use in education. Lasting change does not come from tools alone. Teachers' knowledge of their students and contexts makes them essential decision-makers in how AI is introduced and used. Supporting teacher agency with time, trust, and community will lead to more equitable and effective AI integration.
3. How and when AI is used matters more than whether it is used. Concerns about overreliance and cognitive offloading are valid, but the solution is not avoidance. Thoughtful scaffolding that encourages students to build foundational skills first and use AI to extend, reflect on, or deepen their thinking helps preserve human agency while benefiting from AI's capabilities.

Discussion Questions

In a world where AI tools are becoming part of everyday life, what does it really mean to be "AI literate," and how should people of different ages and roles learn to use AI thoughtfully rather than passively?

How can schools, families, workplaces, and communities share responsibility for supporting meaningful and ethical AI use, while still encouraging curiosity, creativity, and human judgment?

Relevant Resources

To explore studies referenced in this podcast see below:

- Reporting on Class Size and Complexity, Aggression, and Artificial Intelligence (AI) in Alberta's K–12 Schools (Fall 2023)
- Literacy and Numeracy Screeners, Classroom Conditions, Cellphone Bans and AI in Alberta's K–12 Schools (2025)
- Your Brain on ChatGPT: Accumulation of Cognitive Debt When Using an AI Assistant for Essay Writing Task

References

Alberta Machine Intelligence Institute (Amii). (2026, January 20). *AI as a Thought Partner in Schools with Jill Kowalchuk | Approximately Correct Podcast*. Amii. https://www.amii.ca/updates-insights/why-ai-isn-t-as-scary-as-you-think-with-michael-littman-approximately-correct-podcast

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